

Amharic Typing

with Keyman — A Practical Guide

አማርኛ መጻፍ

Learn to type every Amharic letter, number, and punctuation mark using a simple phonetic (sound-matching) system.

This guide covers everything you need to start typing in Amharic using the Keyman Amharic keyboard. No prior experience needed — if you can type in English, you can type in Amharic.

1. How the Keyman Amharic Keyboard Works

The Keyman Amharic keyboard uses a phonetic system — you type the sounds of Amharic words using English letters, and the keyboard converts them into the correct Amharic (Ethiopic) script. Think of it as typing how a word sounds in Amharic.

For example, the Amharic greeting meaning "hello/peace" is pronounced "selam". Just type those English letters:

selam		ሰላም	Hello / Peace
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The Seven Orders (ቤተሰቦች)

Every Amharic consonant has seven forms, one per vowel sound — called orders. Below is the full set for the letter "M" as an example:

Order	Name	Vowel sound	Type	Result
1st	ግዕዝ	–e– (like "men")	me	ጠ
2nd	ካዕብ	–u– (like "moon")	mu	ጡ
3rd	ሣልስ	–i– (like "meet")	mi	ጢ
4th	ራብዕ	–a– (like "ma")	ma	ጣ
5th	ኃምስ	–ie– (like "meh")	mie	ጤ
6th	ሳድስ	no vowel (neutral)	m	ጥ
7th	ሳብዕ	–o– (like "more")	mo	ጦ

Tip: The 6th order is typed with the consonant alone — no vowel. Example: m = ጥ s = ሰ b = ብ

2. The Four Typing Rules

Because Amharic has more sounds than English, four special rules extend the phonetic system to cover every letter.

Rule 1 — Capital Letters for Emphatic Sounds

Some Amharic sounds are stronger versions of English sounds. For these, type the CAPITAL (uppercase) letter. For example, the letter ጠ is a stronger "T" — so type capital T:

Te		ጠ	Emphatic T
Tu		ጡ	
Ti		ጢ	
Ta		ጣ	
T		ጥ	6th order

The full phrase "How are you?" (ጤናይሰጥልኝ) uses this rule:

TienaysTlN		ጤናይሰጥልኝ	"How are you?" (informal)
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Rule 2 — Double Letters for Rare Sounds

For sounds that are even more distinct, type the same key twice. If the capital does not give the letter you want, try doubling it:

se		ሰ	Regular S
sse		ሠ	Rare S (older letter)

If both capital and double are needed, use double capital:

SSe		ፀ	Double-capital
SSeHey		ፀሐይ	"Sun"

Rule 3 — Extra Vowel After "u" for Rounded-Lip Letters

Some Amharic letters are pronounced with rounded lips (like saying "w" while making the consonant). Type: consonant + u + extra vowel:

mua		ሚ	M + rounded lips + A
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gua		ጒ	G + rounded lips + A
guie		ጒ፤	G + rounded lips + IE
kua		ኳ	K + rounded lips + A

Rule 4 — Apostrophe to Separate 6th-Order + Vowel

Normally typing a vowel after a consonant creates a single combined letter. But some words need the bare consonant followed by a separate vowel. Use an apostrophe (') between them to keep them apart:

gebr'iel		ገብርኤል	"Gabriel" — not
m'eeraf		ምዕራፍ	"Chapter/West"
mel'ak		መልአክ	"Angel"

Note: To type a literal apostrophe in your text, type it twice: k" produces ክ'

3. Complete Letter Reference

Every letter family with all seven orders. The Amharic letter is shown above; the key to type is below it.

ሆይ (h)	ግዕዝ 1st	ካዕብ 2nd	ሣልስ 3rd	ራብዕ 4th	ኃምስ 5th	ሳድስ 6th	ሳብዕ 7th
	ሀ	ሁ	ሂ	ሃ	ሄ	ህ	ሆ
	he	hu	hi	ha	hie	h	ho
ላዊ (l)	ግዕዝ 1st	ካዕብ 2nd	ሣልስ 3rd	ራብዕ 4th	ኃምስ 5th	ሳድስ 6th	ሳብዕ 7th
	ለ	ሉ	ሊ	ላ	ሌ	ል	ሎ
	le	lu	li	la	lie	l	lo
ሐውት (H)	ግዕዝ 1st	ካዕብ 2nd	ሣልስ 3rd	ራብዕ 4th	ኃምስ 5th	ሳድስ 6th	ሳብዕ 7th
	ሐ	ሑ	ሒ	ሓ	ሔ	ሕ	ሐ
	He	Hu	Hi	Ha	Hie	H	Ho
ማይ (m)	ግዕዝ 1st	ካዕብ 2nd	ሣልስ 3rd	ራብዕ 4th	ኃምስ 5th	ሳድስ 6th	ሳብዕ 7th
	መ	ሙ	ሚ	ማ	ሜ	ም	ሞ
	me	mu	mi	ma	mie	m	mo
ሠውት (ss)	ግዕዝ 1st	ካዕብ 2nd	ሣልስ 3rd	ራብዕ 4th	ኃምስ 5th	ሳድስ 6th	ሳብዕ 7th
	ሠ	ሡ	ሢ	ሣ	ሤ	ሥ	ሦ
	sse	ssu	ssi	ssa	ssie	ss	ssu
ርእስ (r)	ግዕዝ 1st	ካዕብ 2nd	ሣልስ 3rd	ራብዕ 4th	ኃምስ 5th	ሳድስ 6th	ሳብዕ 7th
	ረ	ሩ	ሪ	ራ	ሪ	ር	ሮ
	re	ru	ri	ra	rie	r	ro
ሳት (s)	ግዕዝ 1st	ካዕብ 2nd	ሣልስ 3rd	ራብዕ 4th	ኃምስ 5th	ሳድስ 6th	ሳብዕ 7th
	ሰ	ሱ	ሲ	ሳ	ሴ	ሰ	ሶ
	se	su	si	sa	sie	s	so
ኧ-ሳት (x)	ግዕዝ 1st	ካዕብ 2nd	ሣልስ 3rd	ራብዕ 4th	ኃምስ 5th	ሳድስ 6th	ሳብዕ 7th
	ኧ	ኧ	ኧ	ኧ	ኧ	ኧ	ኧ
	xe	xu	xi	xa	xie	x	xo
ቃፍ (q)	ግዕዝ 1st	ካዕብ 2nd	ሣልስ 3rd	ራብዕ 4th	ኃምስ 5th	ሳድስ 6th	ሳብዕ 7th
	ቀ	ቁ	ቂ	ቃ	ቄ	ቅ	ቆ
	qe	qu	qi	qa	qie	q	qo

ቤት (b)	ግዕዝ 1st	ካዕብ 2nd	ሣልስ 3rd	ራብዕ 4th	ኃምስ 5th	ሳድስ 6th	ሳብዕ 7th
	በ	ቡ	ቢ	ባ	ቤ	ብ	ቦ
	be	bu	bi	ba	bie	b	bo

ቪ-ቤት (v)	ግዕዝ 1st	ካዕብ 2nd	ሣልስ 3rd	ራብዕ 4th	ኃምስ 5th	ሳድስ 6th	ሳብዕ 7th
	ቨ	ቩ	ቪ	ባ	ቤ	ብ	ቦ
	ve	vu	vi	va	vie	v	vo

ታው (t)	ግዕዝ 1st	ካዕብ 2nd	ሣልስ 3rd	ራብዕ 4th	ኃምስ 5th	ሳድስ 6th	ሳብዕ 7th
	ተ	ቲ	ቲ	ታ	ቲ	ት	ቶ
	te	tu	ti	ta	tie	t	to

ቻ-ታው (c)	ግዕዝ 1st	ካዕብ 2nd	ሣልስ 3rd	ራብዕ 4th	ኃምስ 5th	ሳድስ 6th	ሳብዕ 7th
	ቸ	ቸ	ቸ	ቻ	ቸ	ቸ	ቸ
	ce	cu	ci	ca	cie	c	co

ካርም (hh)	ግዕዝ 1st	ካዕብ 2nd	ሣልስ 3rd	ራብዕ 4th	ኃምስ 5th	ሳድስ 6th	ሳብዕ 7th
	ካ	ካ	ካ	ካ	ካ	ካ	ካ
	hhe	hhu	hhi	hha	hhie	hh	hho

ክሐስ (n)	ግዕዝ 1st	ካዕብ 2nd	ሣልስ 3rd	ራብዕ 4th	ኃምስ 5th	ሳድስ 6th	ሳብዕ 7th
	ክ	ክ	ክ	ክ	ክ	ክ	ክ
	ne	nu	ni	na	nie	n	no

ኛ-ክሐስ (N)	ግዕዝ 1st	ካዕብ 2nd	ሣልስ 3rd	ራብዕ 4th	ኃምስ 5th	ሳድስ 6th	ሳብዕ 7th
	ኛ	ኛ	ኛ	ኛ	ኛ	ኛ	ኛ
	Ne	Nu	Ni	Na	Nie	N	No

አልፍ (a)	ግዕዝ 1st	ካዕብ 2nd	ሣልስ 3rd	ራብዕ 4th	ኃምስ 5th	ሳድስ 6th	ሳብዕ 7th
	አ	አ	አ	አ	አ	አ	አ
	a	u	i	aaaa	ie	e	o

ካፍ (k)	ግዕዝ 1st	ካዕብ 2nd	ሣልስ 3rd	ራብዕ 4th	ኃምስ 5th	ሳድስ 6th	ሳብዕ 7th
	ክ	ክ	ክ	ክ	ክ	ክ	ክ
	ke	ku	ki	ka	kie	k	ko

ኸ-ካፍ (K)	ግዕዝ 1st	ካዕብ 2nd	ሣልስ 3rd	ራብዕ 4th	ኃምስ 5th	ሳድስ 6th	ሳብዕ 7th
	ኸ	ኸ	ኸ	ኸ	ኸ	ኸ	ኸ
	Ke	Ku	Ki	Ka	Kie	K	Ko

ወዌ (w)	ግዕዝ 1st	ካዕብ 2nd	ሣልስ 3rd	ራብዕ 4th	ኃምስ 5th	ሳድስ 6th	ሳብዕ 7th
	ወ	ዉ	ዐ	ዑ	ዒ	ዋ	ዖ
	we	wu	wi	wa	wie	w	wo

ዐይን (aa)	ግዕዝ 1st	ካዕብ 2nd	ሣልስ 3rd	ራብዕ 4th	ኃምስ 5th	ሳድስ 6th	ሳብዕ 7th
	ዐ	ዑ	ዒ	ዓ	ዔ	ዕ	ዖ
	aaa	uu	ii	aa	iie	ee	oo

ዘይ (z)	ግዕዝ 1st	ካዕብ 2nd	ሣልስ 3rd	ራብዕ 4th	ኃምስ 5th	ሳድስ 6th	ሳብዕ 7th
	ዘ	ዙ	ዚ	ዛ	ዞ	ዝ	ዞ
	ze	zu	zi	za	zie	z	zo

ዠ-ዣይ (Z)	ግዕዝ 1st	ካዕብ 2nd	ሣልስ 3rd	ራብዕ 4th	ኃምስ 5th	ሳድስ 6th	ሳብዕ 7th
	ዠ	ዡ	ዢ	ዣ	ዤ	ዥ	ዦ
	Ze	Zu	Zi	Za	Zie	Z	Zo

የመነ (y)	ግዕዝ 1st	ካዕብ 2nd	ሣልስ 3rd	ራብዕ 4th	ኃምስ 5th	ሳድስ 6th	ሳብዕ 7th
	የ	ዩ	ዪ	ያ	ይ	ይ	ዮ
	ye	yu	yi	ya	yie	y	yo

ድንት (d)	ግዕዝ 1st	ካዕብ 2nd	ሣልስ 3rd	ራብዕ 4th	ኃምስ 5th	ሳድስ 6th	ሳብዕ 7th
	ደ	ዱ	ዲ	ዳ	ዴ	ድ	ዶ
	de	du	di	da	die	d	do

ጅ-ድንት (j)	ግዕዝ 1st	ካዕብ 2nd	ሣልስ 3rd	ራብዕ 4th	ኃምስ 5th	ሳድስ 6th	ሳብዕ 7th
	ጅ	ጁ	ጂ	ጃ	ጄ	ጅ	ጆ
	je	ju	ji	ja	jie	j	jo

ገምል (g)	ግዕዝ 1st	ካዕብ 2nd	ሣልስ 3rd	ራብዕ 4th	ኃምስ 5th	ሳድስ 6th	ሳብዕ 7th
	ገ	ጉ	ጊ	ጋ	ጌ	ግ	ጎ
	ge	gu	gi	ga	gie	g	go

ጠይት (T)	ግዕዝ 1st	ካዕብ 2nd	ሣልስ 3rd	ራብዕ 4th	ኃምስ 5th	ሳድስ 6th	ሳብዕ 7th
	ጠ	ጡ	ጢ	ጣ	ጤ	ጥ	ጦ
	Te	Tu	Ti	Ta	Tie	T	To

ጨ-ጠይት (C)	ግዕዝ 1st	ካዕብ 2nd	ሣልስ 3rd	ራብዕ 4th	ኃምስ 5th	ሳድስ 6th	ሳብዕ 7th
	ጨ	ጡ	ጢ	ጣ	ጤ	ጥ	ጦ
	Ce	Cu	Ci	Ca	Cie	C	Co

ጸይት (P)	ግዕዝ 1st	ካዕብ 2nd	ሣልስ 3rd	ራብዕ 4th	ኃምስ 5th	ሳድስ 6th	ሳብዕ 7th
	ጸ	ጸ፡	ጸ፡፡	ጸ፡፡፡	ጸ፡፡፡፡	ጸ፡፡፡፡፡	ጸ፡፡፡፡፡፡
	Pe	Pu	Pi	Pa	Pie	P	Po

ጸይይ (S)	ግዕዝ 1st	ካዕብ 2nd	ሣልስ 3rd	ራብዕ 4th	ኃምስ 5th	ሳድስ 6th	ሳብዕ 7th
	ጸ	ጸ፡	ጸ፡፡	ጸ፡፡፡	ጸ፡፡፡፡	ጸ፡፡፡፡፡	ጸ፡፡፡፡፡፡
	Se	Su	Si	Sa	Sie	S	So

ፀጸ (SS)	ግዕዝ 1st	ካዕብ 2nd	ሣልስ 3rd	ራብዕ 4th	ኃምስ 5th	ሳድስ 6th	ሳብዕ 7th
	ፀ	ፀ፡	ፀ፡፡	ፀ፡፡፡	ፀ፡፡፡፡	ፀ፡፡፡፡፡	ፀ፡፡፡፡፡፡
	SSe	SSu	SSi	SSa	SSie	SS	SSo

ኦፍ (f)	ግዕዝ 1st	ካዕብ 2nd	ሣልስ 3rd	ራብዕ 4th	ኃምስ 5th	ሳድስ 6th	ሳብዕ 7th
	ፈ	ፈ፡	ፈ፡፡	ፈ፡፡፡	ፈ፡፡፡፡	ፈ፡፡፡፡፡	ፈ፡፡፡፡፡፡
	fe	fu	fi	fa	fie	f	fo

ፕሳ (p)	ግዕዝ 1st	ካዕብ 2nd	ሣልስ 3rd	ራብዕ 4th	ኃምስ 5th	ሳድስ 6th	ሳብዕ 7th
	ፕ	ፕ፡	ፕ፡፡	ፕ፡፡፡	ፕ፡፡፡፡	ፕ፡፡፡፡፡	ፕ፡፡፡፡፡፡
	pe	pu	pi	pa	pie	p	po

4. Rounded-Lip (Labialized) Letters

Type: consonant + u + extra vowel

Type	Result	Type	Result	Type	Result
Hua	ሒ	mua	ሚ	rua	ረ
sua	ሱ	que	ቄ	qua	ቋ
bua	ቢ	cua	ቸ	hue	ኸ
hua	ኸ	nua	ኸ	Nua	ኸ
kue	ኸ	kua	ኸ	gua	ኸ
guie	ኸ	Tua	ኸ	Cua	ኸ
Pua	ኸ	Sua	ኸ	fua	ኸ
pua	ኸ				

5. Ethiopic Numbers

Type a hash mark (#) followed by the Arabic number:

#1		፩	One
#10		፲	Ten
#100		፳	One hundred
#10000		፷፻	Ten thousand

Type	Result	Type	Result	Type	Result
#1	፩	#2	፪	#3	፫
#4	፬	#5	፭	#6	፮
#7	፯	#8	፰	#9	፱
#10	፲	#20	፳	#30	፴
#40	፴	#50	፵	#60	፶
#70	፷	#80	፸	#90	፹
#100	፷፻	#1000	፷፻፲፱	#10000	፷፻፲፱፻፹፻

Note: To type a literal # before a number, type ## (double hash).

6. Punctuation

Ethiopic punctuation is produced by typing the similar key twice (or more). All standard English punctuation works normally.

Symbol	Type	Meaning
:	:	Word separator (classical texts)
::	::	Full stop — end of sentence
፡	,	Comma — pause within a sentence
፤	;	Semicolon — stronger pause
:-	:-	Introduces a list or quote
፥	, ,	Double comma — paragraph mark
※	: +	Section mark
※	: #	Book/passage mark
‹	<	Single left quotation mark
›	>	Single right quotation mark
«	<<	Double left quotation mark
»	>>	Double right quotation mark

7. Quick Reference

Situation	What to do	Example
Normal letter	consonant + vowel letter	se= ma= bo=
6th order (no vowel)	consonant only	m= s= b=
Emphatic/strong sound	Use CAPITAL letter	Te= Ce= Pe=
Rare similar-sounding letter	Double the lowercase key	sse= SSe=
Rounded-lip letter	consonant + u + extra vowel	mua= gua=
Bare consonant + vowel	Insert apostrophe ' between	gebr'iel=
Literal apostrophe in text	Type " (double apostrophe)	k' '= '
Ethiopic numeral	# + number	#1= #10= #100=
Literal # before number	Type ## (double hash)	##=#
Ethiopic punctuation	Type similar key twice+	::= ,,= <=<«

Practice Words

Try typing these common words to practice what you have learned:

selam		ሰላም	Hello / Peace
ameseginalehu		አመሰግናለሁ	Thank you
ishi		እሺ	Okay / Yes
aye		አይ	No
bet		ቤት	House
TienaysTlN		ጤናይሰጥልኝ	How are you?

For a full practice document visit: <http://keyboards.ethiopic.org/docs/AmharicTypingPractice.docx>